

Decision process

Until 1 May 2028 the export of live sheep by sea may continue under the Export Control Act 2020 without caps or quotas. The export regulatory requirements, including the animal welfare requirements, remain in place.

Other livestock exports continue, including of live cattle and live sheep by air.

Timeline

The Australian Government decided how and when to phase out live sheep exports by sea based on careful consideration of the advice of an independent panel.

March 2023

The panel was appointed and undertook extensive consultation. It considered over 800 written submissions, 3,300 survey responses, a wide range of existing data and specifically commissioned analysis.

A summary of the panel's consultation process and copies of information are available our [Have Your Say](#) page.

October 2023

The panel's report was provided to government on 25 October 2023.

May 2024

- The government response to the panel recommendations was released with the report on 11 May 2024.
- Legislation to prohibit the export of live sheep by sea on and after 1 May 2028 was introduced into the House of Representatives on 30 May 2024.

June to July 2024

- The proposed legislation was referred to the House of Representatives Standing Committee on Agriculture for inquiry on 3 June 2024.
- The department made a submission to inquiry.
- The amendments to the Export Control Act 2020 to end the trade on 1 May 2028 came into effect on 10 July 2024.

Co-design of transition programs

As part of the \$139.8m transition assistance package, the Australian Government committed to a co-design process to enable industry to inform how funding under the Producer and supply chain program would be allocated.

Workshops

A total of 16 co-design workshops were held in February 2025.

- The first 8 workshops focused on challenges and opportunities to identify transition needs.
- The remaining 8 focused on ideas to meet those needs by designing possible transition packages.

Sessions were also held with peak bodies and industry representatives to help identify key areas for co-design and ensure the right people contributed to this process.

Objectives

The key objectives of the workshops were to:

- explore the challenges and opportunities presented by the transition process
- co-design ideas and measures to assist industry to respond to the phase out
- identify features of a future thriving sheep and wool industry.

Participants

We partnered with peak bodies from the sheep and farming sectors to identify 300 participants across the supply chain who were invited to the workshops.

This approach ensured that perspectives from all parts of the industry—from producers, livestock agents, exporters, shearers and beyond—were heard and considered.

Locations

Co-design sessions have now been held in 13 locations. These were Albany, Boyanup, Cranbrook, Darkan, Esperance, Fremantle, Kojonup, Lake Grace, Merredin, Moora, Narrogin, Perth and York.

Key ideas

The discussions brought together a diverse range of expertise from industry and community representatives. They also generated many ideas to enhance confidence and profitability in the industry.

Strengthen marketability

- Improve the value of light lambs through commercially viable confined feeding and feedlots (on-farm, satellite, and near processors)

- Genetic improvements to produce faster-finishing lambs.

Increase competition and demand for wether lambs

- Support new processing facilities and forward price contracts
- Rebrand hogget lamb
- Secure trade with the Middle East and the European Union.

Secure logistics and processing capacity

Ensure reliable processing and supply chain operations through:

- accurate demand forecasting
- maintaining west-to-east road transport route
- extended operational months of abattoirs
- increased air freight for chilled meat exports
- competitive port pricing.

Enhance supply chain transparency

- Leverage electronic identification (EID) systems to provide growers with feedback on carcase values
- Integrate forward contracts from abattoirs as a condition of funding
- Support government efforts to establish large offshore markets to facilitate forward contracts with growers
- Expand extension services to strengthen collaboration between researchers, grower groups, and producers
- Foster trust across the supply chain.

Provide a clear industry strategy

Establish a long-term strategy for the sheep and wool industry in WA. Ensure it is underpinned by sound economic analysis and accurate forecasts of future flock sizes and wool production volumes.

Strengthen government-industry collaboration

Develop an ongoing mechanism for a more coordinated industry voice in government discussions. This could include a strong focus on highlighting the economic, food security, community, animal welfare, and environmental contributions of WA's sheep and wool sector.

Ongoing collaboration

Discussions also underscored the importance of continued dialogue between industry, government, and regional communities. They also highlighted the need to strengthen public understanding of agriculture's role in both regional and urban contexts.

Participants emphasised that any new programs should build upon, rather than duplicate, existing initiatives across all levels of government.

Programs and grants

Final programs were decided based on the key findings and priorities identified through the workshops.

See more information on the [co-designed programs and grants](#).

Download resources

Transition Assistance Package – July 2025

- [Sheep Industry Transition Assistance Package: Transition assistance for sheep producers and the supply chain for the phase out of live sheep exports by sea \(PDF 1.1 MB\)](#)
- [Sheep Industry Transition Assistance Package: Transition assistance for sheep producers and the supply chain for the phase out of live sheep exports by sea \(DOCX 894 KB\)](#)

Think Place report into co-designing the \$45.5 million producer and supply chain assistance package– July 2025

Response to the House of Representatives Standing Committee on Agriculture advisory report – November 2024

- [Australian Government Response to the House of Representatives Standing Committee on Agriculture advisory report: Inquiry into the Export Control Amendment \(Ending Live Sheep Exports by Sea\) Bill 2024 \(PDF 114 KB\)](#)
- [Australian Government Response to the House of Representatives Standing Committee on Agriculture advisory report: Inquiry into the Export Control Amendment \(Ending Live Sheep Exports by Sea\) Bill 2024 \(DOCX 95 KB\)](#)

Submission to the House Committee Inquiry into the Export Control Amendment (Ending Live Sheep Exports by Sea) Bill 2024 – June 2024

- [Department of Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry submission to the House Committee Inquiry \(PDF 917 KB\)](#)
- [Department of Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry submission to the House Committee Inquiry \(DOCX 3.3 MB\)](#)

Response to the Independent Panel Report – May 2024

- [Australian Government Response to the Independent Panel Report \(PDF 1.3 MB\)](#)
- [Australian Government Response to the Independent Panel Report \(DOCX 3.1 MB\)](#)

Independent Panel Report into the phase out of live sheep exports by sea – October 2023

- [Phase Out of Live Sheep Exports by Sea: Independent Panel Report 2023 \(PDF 5.6 MB\)](#)
- [Phase Out of Live Sheep Exports by Sea: Independent Panel Report 2023 \(DOCX 6.0 MB\)](#)

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Source: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/biosecurity-trade/export/controlled-goods/live-animals/livestock/live-sheep-exports-phase-out/decision>